

POLICY FRAMEWORK

Intelligence Architecture Reform

Ireland's intelligence is split across three agencies with no unified structure — unique in Europe. Every comparable state has integrated intelligence. The Commission on Defence Forces flagged this, and the Programme for Government commits to a National Security Agency. This paper proposes the target architecture, the legislative pathway, and the phased transition.

Security Ireland

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IN BRIEF

Ireland's intelligence system is split between military intelligence (IMIS, formerly J2), police intelligence (Garda GNCSIS, formerly CSB), and cyber (NCSC)—three agencies under three departments with no unified structure. This fragmentation is unique in Europe; every comparable European state has integrated or coordinated intelligence: the UK under the Joint Intelligence Committee, France under the *Coordinateur National du Renseignement*, Germany under the *Bundeskanzleramt*, the Netherlands through joint SIGINT, and even Austria—constitutionally neutral like Ireland—unified its domestic intelligence through the DSN reform in 2022.

The Commission on the Defence Forces (2022) flagged the problem and the Programme for Government (2025) committed to a review of national security structures within six months. Fianna Fáil's election manifesto proposed a standalone National Security and Intelligence Agency, but that proposal did not make it into the Programme for Government.

This paper maps the current architecture, compares it to peer states, proposes a target architecture, identifies the legislative pathway, and outlines the phased transition. Intelligence reform is the prerequisite for everything else. Without unified intelligence, maritime surveillance, subsea protection, and cyber defence cannot be coordinated as a single system.



Figure 1: Ireland's current intelligence architecture. Three agencies under three departments—IMIS (Defence), GNCSIS (Justice), NCSC (Communications)—with no unified structure. The National Security Committee provides coordination but has no operational authority or unified tasking capability. No other EU member state operates this way.

The current system: three silos

Ireland's intelligence architecture is not merely under-resourced; it is structurally fragmented in a way that no other European state replicates. Three agencies, each under a different government department, perform intelligence functions with no unified analytical capability, no joint tasking authority, and no shared intelligence platform.

The Irish Military Intelligence Service (IMIS), renamed from J2 in July 2025, is the intelligence branch of the Defence Forces. It operates domestic and foreign intelligence sections, providing intelligence to the Government concerning threats to the security of the state from internal and external sources. IMIS draws staff from the Army, Naval Service, and Air Corps. The Defence Forces Intelligence School was formalised in 2025, establishing a professional pathway for military intelligence careers. Regional intelligence hubs were established at military installations during 2025. IMIS reports to the Department of Defence. Its budget and personnel numbers are classified; the only publicly known funding is the €2 million Secret Service budget shared with the Garda.

The Garda National Crime and Security Intelligence Service (GNCSIS), formerly the Crime and Security Branch (CSB), is both a security and organised crime intelligence service with a large operational arm, including firearms operations and counter-terrorism investigations. It reports to the Department of Justice. The Commission on the Future of Policing (2018) called for a ring-fenced budget and the ability to recruit specialist expertise directly and quickly, describing this as a 'matter of urgency.' Those recommendations have yet to be fully implemented. A new

multi-storey, high-security facility for the GNCSIS at Garda HQ is planned but expected to take five years to build.

The National Cyber Security Centre (NCSC) reports to the Department of Communications (now the Department of the Environment, Climate and Communications). It is responsible for cyber threat detection, incident response, and the transposition of the EU's NIS2 Directive into Irish law. The NCSC remains under-resourced. Ireland is subject to European Commission infringement proceedings for late NIS2 transposition. The General Scheme for the National Cybersecurity Bill is the proposed draft legislation, with an update expected in the first half of 2026.

The National Security Committee (NSC) is the inter-departmental committee chaired by the Secretary General to the Government. It comprises the Garda Commissioner, the Secretary Generals of the Departments of Justice, Defence, and Foreign Affairs, and the Chief of Staff of the Defence Forces. The NSC provides coordination but has no operational authority, no unified tasking capability, and no statutory mandate. The National Security Analysis Centre (NSAC), originally established as a standalone body, was quietly dissolved earlier in 2025 and now operates as a secretariat within the Department of the Taoiseach. It has yet to publish Ireland's first National Security Strategy, initially expected in 2021.

The fragmentation is not a gap to be filled. It is the design of the system. The question is whether a system designed for the absence of coordinated intelligence can be reformed to produce it.

European Intelligence Structures: Peer Comparison

Every comparable European state has integrated or coordinated intelligence. Ireland is the exception.

State	Principal Agencies	Coordination Structure
UK	MI5 / MI6 / GCHQ	Unified under JIC / NSC
France	DGSE / DGSI / ANSSI	Coordinated under CNR
Germany	BND / BfV / BSI	Coordinated under Bundeskanzleramt
Netherlands	AIVD / MIVD	Joint SIGINT organisation (NSO)
Denmark	PET / FE / CFCS	Integrated under Min of Justice
Finland	Supo / FMIS	Unified under PM Office
Sweden	Sapo / MUST / FRA	Coordinated under PM Office
Austria	DSN / Abwehramt	DSN unified (2022 reform)
Ireland	IMIS / GNCSIS / NCSC	No unified structure

Source: Security Ireland analysis. Structures simplified for comparison; actual arrangements vary in detail.

Figure 2: European intelligence structures. Every comparable European state has integrated or coordinated intelligence under a single authority. Ireland is the only EU member state where intelligence operates across three departments with no unified structure.

Why the fragmentation is a binding constraint

The fragmentation of Ireland's intelligence architecture is not merely an organisational inconvenience, it is a binding constraint on every other security capability Ireland is trying to build.

Maritime surveillance requires the fusion of naval patrol data, satellite imagery, AIS tracking, and signals intelligence into a coherent operational picture. When Ireland's seven PESCO projects generate data—from maritime surveillance, subsea infrastructure monitoring, and cyber threat detection—that data must be analysed, fused with bilateral intelligence from the Cork MoU, and converted into actionable assessments. A fragmented intelligence system cannot perform this fusion. IMIS handles military intelligence, the NCSC handles cyber, and the Garda handles internal security—but no agency has the mandate or the capability to produce the integrated threat assessments that the shared security domain requires.

The Cork MoU's cyber cooperation track establishes NCSC-to-NCSC threat intelligence sharing with the UK. But bilateral cyber intelligence must also inform IMIS assessments of hybrid threats and Garda assessments of critical infrastructure risk. In the current architecture, this requires manual coordination between agencies under different departments—a process that is slow, incomplete, and dependent on personal relationships rather than institutional protocols.

The December 2025 drone incident during President Zelensky's visit illustrated the problem in real time. Unidentified drones were detected seventeen kilometres offshore. Portugal's GNR provided drone defence near Leinster House because Ireland could not. The incident involved maritime surveillance (Naval Service), airspace detection (Air Corps, which has no radar), law enforcement (Garda, which operates the only counter-drone system), and cyber assessment (NCSC). Four agencies under three departments, with no unified command or intelligence fusion capability, could not coordinate a response to protect the capital during a high-profile state visit.

The Commission on the Defence Forces (2022) was explicit. It recommended the development of an 'overarching legal and governance framework to ensure optimum coordination and collaboration between the Defence Forces and An Garda Síochána on intelligence matters.' It recommended that the role of Military Intelligence be 'urgently clarified and underpinned' by legislation within a coherent national intelligence architecture. The Government's implementation plan put these recommendations down for 'further evaluation'—originally due by June 2024, now pushed to December 2027.

IMPLEMENTATION SLIPPAGE

The Commission on the Defence Forces made 130 recommendations in 2022. By early 2026, 54 have been completed in four years. The rate is slowing, not accelerating. Intelligence architecture recommendations—the development of an overarching legal framework, the legislative mandate for IMIS, the clarification of special forces roles—have been repeatedly deferred. Original completion dates of 2024 and 2025 have been pushed to December 2027. At the current rate of implementation, the intelligence architecture will not be reformed within this government's term. The

Programme for Government's commitment to a review of national security structures within six months of taking office (due mid-2025) has not yet produced a published outcome.

The target architecture

The target is not a single monolithic intelligence agency on the MI5 or DGSi model. Ireland's scale, constitutional position, and institutional culture make that neither desirable nor achievable. The target is a coordinated architecture in which existing agencies retain operational independence but operate under unified strategic direction, joint tasking, and a shared analytical platform.

National Security and Intelligence Agency (NSIA). A new statutory body with a legislative mandate to provide unified intelligence analysis, joint tasking, and a shared intelligence platform. The NSIA would not absorb IMIS, GNCSIS, or the NCSC; it would sit above them as the integrating layer—receiving raw and processed intelligence from all three agencies, producing fused threat assessments, and tasking collection priorities based on a unified threat picture. The Fianna Fáil election manifesto proposed exactly this structure. The model follows the Dutch approach (where AIVD and MIVD retain independence but share a joint SIGINT organisation, the NSO) and the Finnish approach (where Supo reports to the Ministry of the Interior but operates under PM Office coordination).

National Security Council (elevated). The current NSC should be elevated to a Cabinet-level committee with statutory authority, chaired by the Taoiseach or a designated senior minister. The Programme for Government has committed to establishing a 'new Cabinet

level committee on national security.' This is the governance layer—setting strategic priorities, receiving integrated threat assessments from the NSIA, and making resource allocation decisions. The UK's National Security Council, established in 2010, provides the template.

Shared intelligence platform. A classified, integrated information system that allows all three agencies to share intelligence at appropriate classification levels. This is the technical infrastructure that makes the coordination architecture functional. Without a shared platform, joint tasking and fused analysis remain aspirational. The new GNCSIS facility at Garda HQ provides an opportunity to build this platform from the outset—but only if the specification includes interoperability with IMIS and NCSC systems, which requires a design decision now, not after the building is complete.

Judicial oversight. Any expansion of intelligence coordination requires proportionate oversight. The current oversight framework—a designated judge reviewing surveillance warrants—is inadequate for an integrated intelligence system. The legislation establishing the NSIA should include a statutory Intelligence and Security Committee of the Oireachtas, modelled on the UK's Intelligence and Security Committee of Parliament, with security-cleared members and access to classified material.

Target Architecture: Integrated National Intelligence

From three siloed agencies to a coordinated system under unified strategic direction



Agencies retain operational independence. NSIA provides unified analysis, joint tasking, and a shared intelligence platform.

Figure 3: The target architecture. A National Security and Intelligence Agency provides unified analysis, joint tasking, and a shared platform. Agencies retain operational independence. The National Security Council provides Cabinet-level governance.

The legislative pathway

Intelligence reform requires primary legislation. The current intelligence agencies operate under a patchwork of legal authorities: IMIS under Defence Forces regulations, the Garda under the Garda Síochána Act 2005, and the

NCSC under communications legislation. There is no overarching intelligence statute that defines roles, mandates, coordination obligations, or oversight mechanisms.

A **National Security and Intelligence Act** should establish the NSIA as a statutory body, define its mandate (intelligence analysis, joint tasking, shared platform), specify its relationship to the three operational agencies, create the oversight framework (Oireachtas Intelligence and Security Committee, judicial authorisation for surveillance, Inspector General for intelligence), and provide the legal basis for inter-agency intelligence sharing that currently operates on informal arrangements.

The Act should also clarify the legal mandate for IMIS, which the Commission on Defence Forces identified as an urgent requirement. IMIS currently operates without specific statutory underpinning for its national security intelligence functions—an extraordinary gap for a state agency that conducts intelligence operations both domestically and abroad.

Surveillance reform must accompany the intelligence statute. The Interception of Postal Packets and

Telecommunications Messages (Regulation) Act 1993 is over thirty years old and predates the internet, social media, encrypted communications, and cloud computing. The Communications (Retention of Data) Act 2011 has been partially struck down following EU Court of Justice rulings. The legal framework for intelligence surveillance is obsolete. Any credible intelligence reform must include modernised surveillance legislation with proportionate safeguards.

NIS2 transposition is a parallel requirement. Ireland is subject to infringement proceedings for late transposition of the EU's Network and Information Security Directive. The National Cybersecurity Bill should be expedited and designed to interoperate with the NSIA's threat assessment function—so that cyber threat intelligence flows into the unified analytical platform rather than remaining siloed in the NCSC.

Phased Transition: From Fragmentation to Integration

Three phases over five years. Each phase is independently valuable if the process stalls.



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Figure 4: Phased transition from fragmentation to integration. Phase 1 (coordination) requires no legislation. Phase 2 (legislation) establishes the statutory framework. Phase 3 (integration) delivers the operational capability. Each phase is independently valuable.

The phased transition

Phase 1: Coordination (2026–2027). This phase requires no legislation and can begin immediately. Elevate the National Security Committee to a Cabinet-level committee as committed in the Programme for Government. Appoint a National Security Coordinator—a senior official with cross-departmental authority to direct intelligence tasking. Establish a joint tasking protocol between IMIS, GNCSIS, and NCSC specifying who collects what, who analyses what, and how assessments are shared. Deploy a shared secure communications platform for inter-agency intelligence exchange. Commission the national security structures review promised in the Programme for Government and ensure it produces a public report with specific legislative recommendations.

Phase 2: Legislation (2027–2028). Draft and enact the National Security and Intelligence Act establishing the NSIA, the oversight framework, the legal mandate for IMIS, and the modernised surveillance provisions. Simultaneously, complete NIS2 transposition through the

National Cybersecurity Bill, designed for interoperability with the NSIA's analytical platform. Establish the Oireachtas Intelligence and Security Committee. Begin recruitment for the NSIA's analytical staff—drawing on the existing talent pool across the three agencies and recruiting externally for specialist analytical, technical, and legal expertise.

Phase 3: Integration (2028–2031). The NSIA becomes operational. The unified analysis centre produces integrated threat assessments for the National Security Council. The shared intelligence platform connects IMIS, GNCSIS, and NCSC data streams. Ireland's bilateral intelligence sharing with the UK (through the Cork MoU) and multilateral sharing through PESCO and EU mechanisms flows through the unified platform. The primary radar programme (target 2028) feeds airspace data into the same system. For the first time, Ireland has a single intelligence picture covering maritime, airspace, subsea, energy, and cyber domains.

Risks and constraints

Political resistance. Intelligence reform touches deep institutional sensitivities. The Defence Forces, An Garda Síochána, and the NCSC each have institutional cultures, ministerial relationships, and resource claims that a unified structure would disrupt. Further, the history of mutual distrust between military and police intelligence in Ireland is well documented. The NSIA must be designed as a coordination layer, not a replacement—agencies retain operational independence, and the NSIA provides the integrating function that no individual agency can perform alone.

Civil liberties. Any expansion of intelligence coordination raises legitimate concerns about state surveillance. Ireland's intelligence oversight is currently minimal by European standards. The legislative package must include robust safeguards: judicial authorisation for surveillance, an Inspector General for intelligence, the Oireachtas Intelligence and Security Committee, and data protection provisions that comply with EU law. Intelligence reform without proportionate oversight would be both politically unachievable and constitutionally indefensible.

Capacity. Ireland's intelligence agencies are small. Building a new integrating layer requires analytical talent that is in short supply. The GNCSIS facility will take five years to build, and the NCSC is still recruiting to baseline capability. The phased approach accommodates these constraints—Phase 1 requires no new institutions, only coordination mechanisms that work with existing resources.

The Fianna Fáil manifesto gap. The standalone National Security and Intelligence Agency was proposed in the Fianna Fáil election manifesto but did not make it into the Programme for Government. Instead, the Programme commits to a review. If the review recommends something less than the full NSIA architecture—a coordinator without statutory authority, a shared platform without joint tasking, coordination without mandate—the reform will be insufficient. The review must produce a recommendation for primary legislation, not another coordination mechanism layered on top of the existing fragmentation.

The prerequisite for everything else

Intelligence reform is the prerequisite for everything else Ireland is trying to build in the security domain. Without unified intelligence, the Cork MoU's bilateral cooperation lacks an analytical backbone. Without a shared platform, PESCO project data cannot be fused with bilateral and national intelligence. Without integrated threat assessment, the shared security domain—maritime, airspace, subsea, energy, cyber—cannot be monitored as a single system.

The Commission on Defence Forces identified the problem in 2022. The Programme for Government committed to a review in 2025. The Presidency creates the political space for reform in 2026. The legislative window is 2027–2028. If that window closes without primary legislation establishing a unified intelligence architecture, Ireland will enter the next decade with the same fragmented system that could not coordinate a drone response during a presidential visit.

WHY THIS MATTERS NOW

Ireland's intelligence architecture is the binding constraint on its entire security transition. The Cork MoU, the PESCO projects, the primary radar programme, the counter-drone procurement, the Naval Service fleet renewal—all of these generate data and require coordination that a fragmented intelligence system cannot provide. The Programme for Government has committed to a review of national security structures. The EU Presidency creates political space for reform. The question is whether the review produces a recommendation for primary legislation establishing a National Security and Intelligence Agency—or another coordination mechanism that leaves the fragmentation intact.

SERIES CONTEXT

This policy framework is part of Security Ireland's suite of forward-looking institutional transformation papers. It connects to the UK–Ireland Security Interface (bilateral cooperation requires intelligence backbone), the GFA and the Security Gap (implementation layer requires intelligence coordination), Ireland's Layered Security Cooperation Model (capability transfer between tracks requires fused intelligence), and the Hybrid Threats and Cyber Defence presidency brief (NCSC integration is a prerequisite for the cyber contribution). It draws on the Commission on Defence Forces (2022), the Programme for Government (2025), and European intelligence reform comparative analysis.